



Hegseth’s boasts are too rosy, some say

Downing of F-15 by Iran and risky rescue undercut claims of total dominance

BY JOHN HUDSON, ELLEN NAKASHIMA AND TARA COPP

President Donald Trump has continued to describe the war against Iran as an unqualified success, saying as recently as Monday that the United States was doing “unbelievably well,” while Defense Secretary Pete Hegseth said Tehran had been “embarrassed and humiliated” by U.S. forces.

But Iran’s downing of an F-15E fighter jet and the high-risk rescue operation that ensued showed that Tehran retains the ability to threaten the United States’ military personnel and cast doubt on the statistics Hegseth has promoted in recent weeks, boasting about “complete control of Iranian skies” and “uncontested airspace,” U.S. officials and analysts said.

The chaotic but successful rescue mission has become the clearest indication yet that Hegseth’s repeated claims of air dominance come with serious caveats, and has reinforced concerns inside the Trump administration that his messaging about the war is overly optimistic and risks misinforming both the public and the president.

“Pete is not speaking truth to the president,” one administration official said. “As a result, the president is out there repeating misleading information.”

Though Hegseth has claimed for weeks that Iran has “no air defenses” and could do “nothing” about U.S. air incursions, Trump acknowledged during his White House news conference Monday that a shoulder-fired “heat-seeking missile” downed the F-15 that left two U.S. airmen temporarily stranded deep inside Iranian territory.

“He got lucky. It was a lucky hit,” Trump said.

SEE CLAIMS ON A7



FRANCISCO SECO/AP

Women visit a shrine Tuesday in Tehran. President Donald Trump said a 10-point proposal from Iran was a “workable basis” for talks.

As president escalates, Iranian civilians fear they will pay price

BY SUSANNAH GEORGE, ASAL ABASIAN AND BURHAN YUKSEKKAS

President Donald Trump has said Iranians welcome expanded U.S. attacks even as he threatens to destroy key infrastructure and bomb their country “back to the stone ages” in a now-delayed effort to make Tehran reopen the Strait of Hormuz.

“All I can tell you is they want freedom. They have lived in a world that you know nothing about. It’s a violent, horrible world where if you protest, you are shot,” Trump said at a news conference Monday. “They want us to keep bombing.”

People in Iran say the reality is more complex. Many fear that if the war escalates further, it could wreak long-term havoc on the country’s economy, leaving civilians to pay the price.

A 27-year-old teacher from Tehran said he almost felt positive about the war when it began,

with U.S.-Israeli attacks that killed the country’s supreme leader, Ayatollah Ali Khamenei. But as strikes began shifting to economic and industrial targets, “the reaction shifted completely,” he said, speaking from Qom, having fled the capital. “I felt deeply upset, and so did those around me.”

Like others in Iran interviewed for this article, he spoke via voice memos shared on a messaging app, on the condition of anonymity for fear of reprisal.

“It was no longer just about the regime,” the teacher said. “These are directly tied to people’s lives and to the country’s economic future. This destruction creates a much deeper sense of insecurity.”

Nearly 1,500 civilians have been killed since Feb. 28, according to a report released late last month by a consortium of human rights groups, which provided the most comprehensive estimate yet of the war’s growing

civilian toll. Strikes on infrastructure that could serve both civilian and military needs were among the major factors contributing to the loss of civilian life, the report found.

“The key point is that infrastructure ultimately constitutes a national asset — one that belongs to the people, not the regime,” a 37-year-old factory manager from Tehran said.

“Even if we have serious grievances with the government, we cannot — under any circumstances — condone the destruction of infrastructure,” the factory manager said. Such attacks are “effectively directed at the population itself.”

Communicating with people in Iran remains extremely difficult under a near-total, government-imposed internet blackout. Those who have managed to stay connected do so with VPNs that allow them to bypass government restrictions and through Starlink internet terminals that

connect via satellite and are strictly outlawed in Iran.

Trump has twice delayed attacks on Iranian infrastructure, saying he wanted to allow more time for talks. Trump initially threatened to destroy Iranian power plants last month and since then, Iran and the United States have exchanged messages and positions, according to officials briefed on the mediation efforts, but do not appear to be nearing a deal.

Last week, the United States struck a suspension bridge outside Tehran, a move Trump said he ordered after Iran’s leaders signaled reluctance to engage in negotiations.

Other U.S. and Israeli airstrikes have hit Iranian factories, universities and medical facilities, including a pharmaceutical production plant and a medical research institute. Iranian state media has reported attacks on a cement factory in southern Iran

SEE CIVILIANS ON A10

2-week delay on Iran assault

THREAT TO WIPE OUT ‘WHOLE CIVILIZATION’

Trump claims progress in talks to reopen strait

BY KAREN DEYOUNG, ISAAC ARNSDORF, SAMMY WESTFALL AND TARA COPP

Just 90 minutes before President Donald Trump’s 8 p.m. deadline to “wipe out a whole civilization” with massive strikes on Iran’s energy infrastructure and bridges, he granted a two-week extension for diplomacy to continue.

“Subject to the Islamic Republic of Iran agreeing to the COMPLETE, IMMEDIATE and SAFE OPENING of the Strait of Hormuz,” Trump said on social media, “I agree to suspend the bombing and attack of Iran for a period of two weeks.”

“We have already met and exceeded all Military objectives and are very far along with a definitive Agreement concerning Longterm PEACE with Iran,” Trump said. A 10-point proposal received from Tehran, he said, was a “workable basis on which to negotiate.”

Trump added, “This will be a double-sided CEASEFIRE!”

Trump said his decision was in response to an appeal from Pakistani Prime Minister Shehbaz Sharif and military chief Gen. Asim Munir, whose government has been serving as mediator between the United States and Iran.

“Diplomatic efforts for peaceful settlement are progressing steadily,” Sharif said in a post on social media. “I earnestly request

SEE IRAN ON A11

Papal rebuke: Pope Leo decries president’s apocalyptic threat. **A10**

War crimes? Rhetoric puts troops in a legal and moral quandary. **A11**

Epic drought forces farmers into a ‘bleak’ situation

And if forecasts of continued heat and lack of rain hold, it could affect the nation’s food supply

BY SARAH KAPLAN

Justin Perry’s family has been farming the rolling hills of the Nebraska panhandle for four generations, but none of them can remember a winter as warm and parched as this one.

There was no steady rain to gently soak the soil. No blanket of snow to insulate the fields and pasture. Just warm, dry winds that swept across the landscape, sucking moisture from every inch of exposed earth.

Now spring has arrived, along with forecasts for continued drought that could imperil Perry’s winter wheat and summer planting. An extraordinary March heat wave sent temperatures soaring to almost 90 degrees, further baking the soil. And to the north, Perry can see smoke billowing from record-setting wildfires that have consumed hundreds of thousands of acres of ranches and farmland.

“This is feeling really bleak,” Perry said. “This might be one of those scenarios that breaks some guys.”

SEE DROUGHT ON A4



BRITTANY PETERSON/AP

Philip Anderson’s pasture in Walden, Colorado, is normally covered with snow in late March.

DHS spending probes reveal unusual roles of Noem aides

A little-known contractor had wide influence over awards and grants

BY BRIANNA SACKS, MARIA SACCHETTI AND MARIANNE LEVINE

On a Monday in mid-March, a group of Department of Homeland Security investigators entered the Federal Emergency Management Agency’s headquarters and headed up to the eighth floor, past two access-controlled doors, and to an office near the administrator’s. The agents roped off the area, copied notebooks left on the desk, and put stacks of documents and equipment in boxes.

That workspace belonged to an influential figure at DHS who had been integral to overseeing much of FEMA’s day-to-day operations — including decisions on grants and awards that are now part of an Office of Inspector General review of contracts issued under

then-Secretary Kristi L. Noem’s leadership, according to several current and former DHS officials, including two with knowledge of the headquarters search.

Kara Voorhies joined DHS early in Trump’s second term and worked closely with Noem’s top aide, Corey Lewandowski, as a contractor. Both held unusual roles at DHS that stationed them at the top echelons of the agency and put them at the center of some of its most controversial and consequential moves over the past year.

Last June, Noem demanded that DHS headquarters approve all contracts worth more than \$100,000, giving top officials significant control over everyday spending and creating major delays. Noem’s successor, Secretary Markwayne Mullin, has swiftly scrapped that rule and said leadership should review contracts valued at more than \$25 million, a cap that he called “appropriate.”

Among the awards that have come under public scrutiny are a \$1 billion contract fast-tracked to a pro-Trump donor last year; a

SEE DHS ON A2

IN THE NEWS

Vance in Hungary The vice president campaigned for Viktor Orban, the far-right nationalist who is the Trump administration’s closest ideological ally in Europe. **A8**

U.S. journalist freed Shelly Kittleson was let go in a prisoner swap after an Iran-backed militia kidnapped her, Iraqi officials said. **A12**

THE NATION
A GOP sheriff in California seized half a million ballots in a lopsided election. **A3**
Bill Gates is set to appear at a House panel in June about his ties to Jeffrey Epstein. **A3**

THE WORLD
Across Asia, as war in Iran drives up fuel prices for motorists worldwide, companies and consumers are facing or preparing for shortages of everyday goods. Even snacks aren’t safe. **A12**

THE ECONOMY
A proposed rule to add alternative assets such as cryptocurrency, private equity, and private credit to 401(k) menus without fear of massive lawsuits is a gift from our billionaire president to rich Wall Street firms, Michelle Singletary writes. **A16**

STYLE
A music festival in London was canceled after Britain banned Ye (Kanye West) over his antisemitic history. **B1**

SPORTS
At least three of the starters who led Michigan to its 69-63 win over UConn could be in the NBA next year. **B7**

THE REGION
D.C. police released body-camera footage showing the moments after a federal agent shot into a D.C. man’s car. **B12**

FOOD
Even as beef prices soar, D.C. has retained a steakhouse reputation, with a slew of new restaurants opening.

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